



STILLED WATERS
A deathly quiet Dal Lake, Apr. 28; below, day after at Pahalgam

ABID BHAT

▶ JAMMU AND KASHMIR

THE VALLEY OF WOES

A booming tourism season had already been felled by Pahalgam. Now Kashmir presents a microcosm of the utter disruption caused to ordinary life at wartime

sliver of redemption remains. If the India-Pakistan situation escalates, tourism won't be the only sector hit, but the contrast is the starkest here. Before the rattle of M4 carbines at Baisaran, the Valley's famed houseboats, hotels and cabs were off to a bumper season. Conflict has killed that in mid-flight.

In recent years, a steady, if fragile, peace had seen tourism numbers swelling—2024 had netted a record 3.5 million footfalls, including 43,654 foreigners, and this year may have been bigger. Some 75 new offbeat destinations beckoned the adventurous, inching ever closer to the LoC, say in Gurez up north, or to the Pir Panjal peaks in Aharbal, Kulgam. Some 125 km north of Srinagar, the 2021 ceasefire had allowed beauteous valleys like Karnah and Keran, enveloping the Kishenganga, to emerge from decades of cross-border shelling that kept humans and habitats in permanent injury.

Takeaways

- **Kashmir's Rs 12,000 crore tourism industry is shrouded by a fog of terror and war**
- **3.5 million footfalls in 2024, and this year promised to be bigger, before Pahalgam**

But it's back to the pall of dread, in all its colours: red alerts, olive-green trucks and the cheerless gloom of bunkers. "For now, this is a gone year," says Amir Anees, who leases camping tents in Gurez's meadow paradise but was forced to move 86 km away to Bandipora town. In the valley he leaves behind, troops, booming artillery and that old disembodied fear—all are building up in equal proportions.

THE SHROUD OF WAR

Even before Operation Sindoor, over half of Kashmir's tourist destinations, 48 out of 87, had been closed. Now, the curtains have fallen even on the exempt hubs like Gulmarg, Sonamarg, Srinagar's Dal Lake and Mughal Gardens and Pahalgam, where the scars are still raw.

Kashmir presents a microcosm of the utter disruption caused to ordinary life at wartime. Verinag, the source of the Jhelum, counted 10,000-odd daily footfalls in April. Now a black shroud of tarpaulin covers some 250 hawkers' carts here—that could symbolise the 'sudden death' imparted to a whole season of normalcy. "We're so ill-fated," says Abdul Rashid, 65, who sells *chai* and *thanda*. He speaks for everyone. ■